DETERMINATION AND RESILIENCE

RAISING LEADERS IN A WAR-TORN COUNTRY

BY AIMEE W

Her due date was approaching. As a mother, there are the normal feelings of anticipation, but for Naw Plaw Htoo, her situation was far more unstable than most. Her husband, a soldier with the Karen National Liberation Army (KNLA), was stationed away from home, and the presence of the oppressive Burma Army constantly threatened her family's safety. One night, with her two- and three-year-old children in tow, she fled her village under the cover of darkness. As the Burma Army began burning homes behind them, she felt the first pains of labor. Only about a 40-minute walk from her village, deep in the jungle, she gave birth to a son; she named him Saw Sun. It would be three years before she was reunited with her husband again. Ten years later, she welcomed another son, Toh.

Sitting with Naw Plaw Htoo and her son Toh, I am struck by her humble confidence and quiet grace. For her, the story of giving birth while fleeing for her life is simply one chapter in a long journey of survival and I sit in amazement at her strength. Now 80 years old, she has lived nearly her entire life in the midst of civil war. Surrounded by oppression and hardship, she has remained resilient—raising children, educating youth, and guiding the next generation toward hope.

I first learned of Naw Plaw Htoo in the 2014 Day of Prayer magazine, which featured two of our FBR leaders. Saw Sun, nicknamed "Koala Bear," was the baby born in the jungle—now a respected leader in Karen State. Toh serves as the director of the Jungle School of Medicine–Kawthoolei. From the moment I read their story, I was struck by the faith and perseverance of the woman they call "Mom." Her courage stayed with me for many years, and in May 2025, I was honored to meet her for the first time.

Born in Hsaw Hti Township in Karen State, Naw Plaw Htoo was the middle of three children. When she was three years old, her father, who had joined the Karen resistance at the start of the Kawthoolei revolution, died in battle. She attended school in her village until grade 4, when the Burma Army burned the entire village down. For years, she and her family moved from place to place, hiding from conflict. At age 15, she was finally able to continue her education and completed grade 9. She dreamed of further schooling, but experienced many setbacks. She pursued Bible school and midwifery training, but after several disappointments, she eventually joined her mother as a village teacher. She taught for three years before marrying—unaware that this path would shape the futures of countless young people.

Below: Naw Plaw Htoo and her son Toh who serves as the director of the Jungle School of Medicine Kawthoolei.

As her children grew and instability continued, Naw Plaw Htoo realized that educational opportunities in their area were scarce. Following God's calling, she returned to teaching. "Everywhere I went, I taught," she said, "because if I did not teach, the children—and my children—would not have the chance to go to school. In the class, they were students and not my children. At home, they were my children." She mostly taught in jungle classrooms, sometimes in simple shelters during rainy seasons. Supplies were scarce; students used slates because paper was unavailable. Occasionally, pens and books were smuggled from Burma Army–controlled areas. With no textbooks, she relied on a simple syllabus and created lessons from scratch. God strengthened her through every season.

Many older villagers would say, "If we are educated or not educated, we both eat rice." But Naw Plaw Htoo remained steadfast: "I want the children to be educated!" She said, "I wanted to go to college, but I didn't have a chance, so I tried my best for my children so they could go to college, work with other people, and do their work well." She doesn't know the number of students she taught—and shaped. She continued teaching well into her 70s. Through every hardship, she saw God's grace, witnessing miracles and provision.

The educational foundation she laid for her own children led them into lives of influence and service. Three graduated from Bible school and became ministers. Saw Sun and Toh continue to serve their people faithfully, using their skills and compassion to help their people in profound ways.

As I look at Naw Plaw Htoo, I am reminded that one woman's faith, determination, and sacrifice can change generations—and that God often begins His greatest works through quiet lives surrendered to Him.

Please pray for:

- Teachers in Burma—that they will have the training, passion, and strength to pour into the next generation.
- "For the dictators—that they will have peace and love in their hearts, and especially that they will know God." — Naw Plaw Htoo
- "For peace, so that everyone can be free and peaceful." — Naw Plaw Htoo